Needs
and
Validations

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Introduction

I have always been interested in why we become who we are. I want to see the patterns and understand how they are formed within our human psyche.

This text moves between childhood and motherhood, between memory and the present, tracing how love, absence, and longing can travel through generations. I explore the question of value, how it's formed, how it is lost, and how it is searched for in others.

To become a mother is not only to care for a child, but to confront the child you once were, and the mother you have. What do you carry with you, and what do you try to protect your children from?

In my work, I try to trace the significant moments that stay with us, the ones that seem to attach themselves to our very being and continue to shape us in every relationship we build as adults:
how love can become control,
how kindness can turn into cruelty.

There are things the mind forgets, but the body still remembers.

It's like I'm stepping into a messy room, where you can tell that something has clearly happened here, but you can't really understand what.

Chapter 1. Please need me

Mother is such a powerful word to me. When I see it written in the title of an artwork, or encounter it in the plot of a book or a film, I am immediately drawn in. Relationships with mothers have always fascinated me; I want to understand every layer of their complexity. In conversation, nothing captivates me more than the tangled, messy world of "mommy issues."

My mother is not obsessed with me -why is that?
The easy answer is that she has nine children, nine versions of who I could have been. No, my family is not deeply religious, and yes, we believe in birth control -but my mother loves babies. She loves them deeply.
I think she loves how they make her feel: like the most important person in the universe. And as the baby, you are the most important person to the most important person in the universe.

But as you grow older, as your chubby cheeks begin to thin, your place in her arms is quietly replaced by a new, delicious baby -and then another, and another, and another. And then you realize you weren't even the first. You were the fourth. And something shifts. You begin to question your worth.

Suddenly, you are no longer so cute. You are often in the way. Your needs become an inconvenience, a burden. And you live like this, trying to make sense of your value through the eyes of others -your siblings, your friends, and eventually men who find you attractive.

Then one day, you carry a baby with chubby cheeks growing inside your own body. And finally, you understand what it truly means to be important to someone. To be the most important person in the universe to another human being.

It is selfish -I know that. I think a large part of having children is selfish. Now I understand how easy it is to become addicted to this feeling of worth.

As I see it, being a middle child means you can go one of two ways. Either you become the quiet one- "the mediator" who sits still, waits to be heard, and tries to keep the peace. Or you become the loud, outcast middle child, the one who doesn't shy away from conflict or difficult situations.

I chose violence.

No, not literal violence. But I had a rage that longed to come out -and it did, often. I don't know where it came from, but somewhere in my early teens it began to grow inside me like a tumor. I had little, or no, control over it. I was not an "easy child," and those around me began to walk on eggshells.

My mother was, and still is, the sweetest. She never yelled. She never said no. In fact, she rarely said much at all. There was a kind of absence in her, a drifting silence I now understand came from trauma buried deep inside her.

She did not have much of a voice. So, I made it my assignment to use mine. I became her voice and her shield. I used to call myself her attack dog.

I started noticing how my family members treated me differently, carefully choosing their words, their tone to keep me calm. But not everyone. My father and my stepfather never hesitated to get in my way -and that was when the swelling broke. For years, I screamed out my frustration. They used to say they saw my eyes turn black. I liked that, I figured that if they couldn't love me, or even respect me, at least they would sort of fear me.

In a home where nothing belonged to me, I found one thing that was mine alone -
my beautiful rage.

When I got pregnant with my first child I was just going to turn 20. The father I had only known for 5 months, and my hole social life was surrounding bars and nightclubs. The situation was not ideal. But somehow it felt right and in my immature mind I was thinking, I have 5 younger siblings, I have been changing diapers since I was seven, my mother did this in my age - I can do this. The months that I was pregnant was really precious. My teenage years was filled with rage, but as my son grew bigger in my belly, my anger slowly ran off. I was happy and I was calm and I felt at peace for the first time in a very long time, like nothing could really hurt me. I lived inside a thin, perfect baby bubble.

And then the day came when my son entered the real world. The delivery day. It hurt like a motherfucker, but all the pain vanished the moment they placed that perfect little baby boy on my chest. Perfect. Warm. Mine.

And just as I lifted my gaze to take in the world beyond the bubble -it burst.

What met my eyes were worried faces staring down at my chest. I can still see it, seventeen years later, as if it were a scene from a movie. My baby's skin was turning blue. That was when the noise hit me -or rather, the absence of it. The room was silent.

The baby wasn't crying.

They rushed him out, into the emergency room. I was left behind with a nurse assigned to watch over me. I was covered in blood and amniotic fluid, and no matter how desperately I wanted to stand up and run after him, my body would not let me.

I asked the nurse to call my mother. My sisters arrived as quickly as they could.

We spent our first night as parents in the maternity ward, while our son spent his night attached to an ECMO machine on another floor in the same building.
All night, we listened to the cries of newborns, healthy babies in the rooms around us.
I had never felt so empty.

The next day, he was flown to Lund for open-heart surgery, less than a day old.
A heart the size of a walnut was going to be cut open. He was placed in intensive care.

When your child is in intensive care, you don't get to stay in the same room, not even in the same building. In Lund, his father and I lived in a patient home for families with newborns. In other words, a house filled with healthy babies. Happy parents. Exhausted parents.

If I wanted breakfast, I had to walk into a dining room full of them -parents who had spent the night rocking their crying, healthy babies to sleep.
I was so jealous it made me sick.

I couldn't stand the sight of a father yawning. He had no idea how luxurious his sleepless night had been. I would have given anything to be tired from comforting a hungry baby, not from lying awake, waiting for a phone call telling me something had gone wrong during the night.

After open-heart surgery, a baby's chest is sometimes left open. It cannot be closed because of the swelling. Days pass, sometimes weeks, before it can be closed again. During that time, the child must be kept under anesthesia.

I couldn't breastfeed. My son was sedated.
Instead, I was given a machine to pump milk from my body. I was told that it was the only thing I could do for him, everything else was out of my hand. I tried for days, but nothing came. Not a single drop.

I always sat beside his tiny bed, holding his hand or having my fingers on his cheeks so he would know I was near.

Then one night, a very weak little hand squeezed my finger.
I froze.

The deep blue eyes I had only seen for a few seconds after his birth were now slightly open, looking at me.
He had woken up.

It wasn't supposed to happen. As soon as the nurse noticed, she gave him more medication, and he drifted back to sleep.

But that moment was enough.

Suddenly, my body responded. Milk began to pour from me, as if someone had turned on a tap.

It felt like he was telling me -*I'm going to make it.*
And my body believed him.

After that, whenever I heard babies crying in the patient home, my breasts would swell and ache, as if it were my own child calling for me.
The pain was everywhere.

When I finally heard my son cry for the first time, he was ten days old.
It was the most beautiful sound I had ever heard.

Later, I was told he wasn't crying for me.
He wasn't crying from hunger. His body was withdrawing from all the medication.

I wish they hadn't told me that.

I was desperate for my mother to come.

Luckily, I was not born with just one mother. I have four. One of my sisters, the one closest to me in age came. She bought me clothes; I had packed for a few days in the hospital, not for months. She made sure I ate. She stayed close, in case I needed her. She comforted me. She tried to lift my spirit - just the way a mother would.

Something in me hardened during those months. Not in a cruel way but in a final way. The idea that life was fair, that love was enough to keep a child safe, quietly disappeared. I lost my innocence there, in hospital corridors that smelled of disinfectant and fear.

Motherhood no longer felt like a bubble. It felt like vigilance. Like responsibility sharpened into anxiety. Love became inseparable from terror. I learned that to be a mother was not to protect your child from pain, but to stand beside them when pain arrived.

From that moment on, nothing felt guaranteed. Not health. Not time. Not even tomorrow. I learned to live inside the uncertainty. That was the beginning of my real motherhood.

I now have three children. Building a family of my own has turned my childhood into a fogged mirror -reflecting it back at me. Every choice, every instinct carry echoes of where I came from. But as I grow older, and gain distance, my perspective widens. What once felt like anger or grief has slowly transformed into wonder and curiosity. How did it become this way? And why?

This is where my artistic practice begins.

Chapter 2. Smother nature

Getting through the trauma of my son's heart surgery left my mind in a constant state of alarm. I had been an angry person before; now I was terrified. Danger seemed to exist everywhere -in every corner, every ordinary moment. Each step, each breath, felt potentially fatal.

Years passed, but my fear of losing my children just became stronger. Slowly it turned into suffocation. I trusted no one with my children. A car ride alone was out of the question. When my father-in-law wanted to take my eldest to their cabin, I said no. I think he began to resent me for it, for never letting them babysit. Then I resented him but then -myself. I wanted my children to experience joy and freedom, but I could not bear the thought of not being close enough to protect them.

I kept them beside me, even in their sleep. When they finally began sleeping in their own beds, I woke up at least one time if not more each night to make sure they were still there, still breathing, not taken, not gone. I checked their temperature repeatedly. I counted their breaths per minute in the dark. I was constantly on guard, as if vigilance alone could keep them safe. Wherever we went I needed to know the closest was to the nearest hospital. Traveling abroad always carried a quiet anxiety: the fear of not knowing where to turn if something suddenly went wrong.

After the surgery, my son developed complications that made him highly vulnerable to pneumonia. From the age of two, he had it over and over again, there has been around sixteen times throughout his childhood. Each infection meant hospital stays, sometimes for ten days at a time. Even now, a single sneeze from him can send a shock wave through my body. He has severe asthma, and for long periods our lives revolved around inhalations, medications, and the sound of his breathing at night.

If I was not present, who would be at constant alert? Who would make sure they were breathing? Who would notice a new bruise, a mark that did not belong on my precious children's bodies?

It became a full-time occupation. Anxiety moved in and took up permanent residence in my life. My body might have been in the room most of the time, but because of my constant fear, my mind was always somewhere else - scanning for threats. I could not hold a conversation with anyone without one part of me listening for the sound of breathing from the next room.

It was a burden, for sure, but it also gave me a sense of purpose. The protection-system I built around my children made me feel like a good mother. Even if I failed at everything else, at least I was succeeding at that.

Looking back, I can see how tightly I held on to that idea. I lost my sense of proportion for a while. I know now that motherhood is not the same as standing guard at all hours, not the same as being a bodyguard permanently on duty. Love cannot be measured by vigilance alone.

It took me a hole lot of therapy to convince me that this wasn't the way to go. I didn't like any of the therapists but one, an older polish lady that sat me down after had spent hours listening to my horror stories about how threatening life was, she looked me in the eyes leaned forward against me and sad – Who ever said that you are the only important person in your children's life?

I tried, slowly, to have other interests. Time away from my kids was unavoidable, I had to eventually start working, and work became a kind of relief. The stress of working forced me to focus on what I was doing, rather than on what was happening at home or at daycare. But the moment I left work, the anxiety rushed back, uninvited and insistent.

It was a huge step to begin working with art. I had to tell my children, "Now it's my time, this is my work time," and they could not be part of it. It didn't contribute financially to the household; on the contrary, it is costly -in both time and money. And yet, it was something I had to do. I had to claim space for myself, even if it felt selfish, even if it meant being away from the children. I needed a room of my own.

My solution to my persistent guilt for my non-profit alone time was to make it my art. If my children became the subjects of my work, they would still be present, and I could still show them that I care -even though I took time away from them.

But that is not the only reason I paint my children. They are also the largest part of my identity. I am a mother -that is what I do, it is all I know, and what I'm proud of. I became a mother before I had fully become myself. In that sense, painting them is like painting the largest and most essential part of my life.

Right now, I find myself in a kind of crisis. My two eldest children are entering the stage of life where childhood and adulthood meet, and the separation feels inevitable. The time has come when they don't need me anymore, or if they do, they are really going out of their way not to show it. It is a constant sorrow, their lack of interest in doing things together, the way everything I do seems embarrassing, the eye rolls every time I speak. My oldest daughter often looks at me as if I have no brain cells left, and she has an exceptional talent for making me feel old and inadequate.

I know that the cutting of the umbilical cord is long overdue and I have had years of practice but I'm still not even close to ready. I know this is natural, and that they will likely come back. But what if they don't? They are beginning to look at their childhood as something that has already passed, a chapter closed and folded away.

In one of my paintings, I am handing my daughter a pair of scissors; she must make the cut between us because I cannot bear it.

Did I do enough? What will they remember, what will they resent me for? Only time will tell, but the waiting for them to want to be near me again is already unbearable. I exist in the echo of what once was, while they walk forward into what is.

Chapter 3. Choose your weapon

From an article in *Uppsala Nya Tidning*, I read about an excavation beneath Uppsala where archaeologists found wood from a juniper tree dating back to the 1400s. How did they know it was juniper? When they scratched the surface, they could still smell the significant scent.

This made me think about Tove Ditlevsen's book *Barndom* (Childhood) and how she writes about the way you can sense the smell of someone's childhood. Growing up poor, she felt certain that the people around her could sense the smell of her upbringing, she writes:

"Man kan inte ta sig ut ur barndomen och den klibbar fast vid en som en lukt*. Man märker den hos andra barn också, och varje barndom har sin speciella lukt. Sin egen känner man inte och ibland är man rädd för att den är värre än de andras."* (Ditlevsen, Tove*, Barndom Ungdom,* Natur & Kultur, page.30)

For my examination exhibition "Please need me" I made nine knives for us nine siblings, out of juniper. I have been thinking about that scent, how I can still recognize it when I scratch the surface, something that reminds me of my own childhood. The knives can be understood as metaphors for the ways we learn to face life. We must defend ourselves with the knife we choose to face life with. The bad always comes with something good, and vice versa, so we must work with what we have been given and sharpen that knife. But however we carve, the scent of its origin never goes away.

My father taught me how to carve when I was very young. We always carved in juniper. I think that was because it came from a very large tree at my dad's country house. It's a small cabin south of Stockholm with no running water or modern amenities, it feels a bit like stepping into a house at Skansen. Something my grandmother and my dad were always very proud of was a huge juniper tree. They used to say it was the biggest one in all of Sweden, although of course there is no way of knowing that. Inside the large tree they built an arbour where you could sit and have afternoon coffee. Unfortunately, the tree eventually rotted and had to be taken down. I believe the carving wood came from that tree.

There is something very relaxing about carving. It is different from painting. In a way it is almost violent at first, when you cut into the wood, but when you move on to the next steps - filing and grinding, it becomes a completely different act. Grinding is careful and almost caring, and it makes the wood smooth, like a baby's bottom.

The knives displayed on the podium are not only symbols of sharpness or violence. One of them is very small, almost harmless. Together they suggest that we develop different strategies for meeting resistance. Like me and my sibling, we look at our upbringing in completely different ways.

Chapter 4. Never ending pets

Before I knew what an artistic practice was, I already understood the desire to have something that was truly my own. Not ownership in the strict sense, but a small world where my presence mattered -where my care made a difference. Looking back, I recognize this impulse as closely tied to how I later approached making the surroundings in my paintings. I think about it as a sort of nesting for the ones I portray. I want them to have a nice colourful space with a sense of calm even if the act in the painting isn't always pleasant. A form of care that did not exist before I brought them into life.

But my nesting didn't begin with me painting surroundings with people I know in them, it didn't even begin with my children, it began long before.

I got myself my first pet when I was about five years old: a snail named Anna. I looked after her, gave her little treats, and made a home for her. I wanted her to sleep on my pillow, but for some strange reason that was not allowed.

Anna was cute, but she didn't really need me. It almost felt as if she didn't care whether I was there or not. What I really wanted was a dog.

I think my mother carried some guilt toward us older siblings, and getting a dog is like putting the biggest, softest bandage on a child. So, one day we got the sweetest little puppy you could imagine. She breathed and snored softly in her sleep -nothing like Anna or the stuffed animals I had.

There was just one small problem: my mother was extremely allergic. Rashes spread across her body, and her throat became terribly itchy. We kept the puppy for a week, but then we had to give her back.

We were devastated.

Growing up, I was something of an expert at nagging, perhaps I still am. I was determined to take care of some kind of animal. I was open to anything; even a lizard would have made me happy. No one else agreed that a lizard would be a good addition to the family, so after years of persistent nagging it was finally decided that we would try another dog.

I was over the moon.

This time it was going to be all mine. A Chinese Crested Dog, Matilda. She was already three years old, so the puppy period wouldn't be a problem. She was the best listener, she knew all my secrets and never even thought to judge. She was truly amazing. She followed me like a shadow wherever I went; I didn't even need to use a leash on her. I loved her dearly. I even remember writing poems about her in my diary. Every day after school I rushed home to take her out. I tried to divide my time carefully between my mom's and my dad's houses so that no one would see her as a burden.

But one day, when I came back from my dad's house -she was gone. My mother had given her away, and I didn't even get the chance to say goodbye. I was beyond devastated.

My poems became truly emo. I did not care for people anymore, every person I knew was a disappointment, nothing like Matilda.

A rage started building up.

To fix my broken heart, my mother did the only thing she could think of: she got me another pet. My sister and I each got a rabbit -for a while. The procedure was always the same. I would get attached and I would care for the little one and I would leave it in its cage or on the bed that I made for them when I went to my dad's house, and one day -because of allergies, lack of time, or simple inconvenience -it would just be gone.

By the time I moved away from home we had owned six dogs, two cats, two mice, two rats, two nymph parakeets, a rabbit, and yes, Anna. All at different times. It became a circular sequence of events: grief over one animal would be comforted by getting a new one, and so on. It's safe to say that the trust was broken, and so was my little emo heart. The empty nests were all that was left.

So, what did I do when my youngest daughter started first grade and I suddenly had some time on my hands? I got a dog, of course. It wasn't because my kids nagged me -it was all me. I nagged their father until he finally gave in.

When he first came home, I was definitely stressed. I kept thinking that it had always been my fault that things never worked out with my pets before. How was I going to make this work? I'm proud to say that our dog just turned three years old and still lives with us. I know that's not much of an achievement, but still it's longer than I ever got to keep a pet growing up and I'm truly happy to see him as part of the family.

Unfortunately, I didn't stop there. I must have developed some kind of hubris, because we have just welcomed a new puppy into the family, a big one this time. Again, it wasn't my kids who were nagging for another dog. In fact, my son told me several times that it wasn't a good idea and that we should just be happy with the perfect dog we already have. But no -I had to get another one. Apparently, there is no end to how much I need to be needed.

Writing this text, I'm starting to think that I might just be a big narcissist.

The horror.

Chapter 5. The Past is yet to come

Melanie Klein says that you carry all the ages you experienced within you. She argues that in order to understand an adults behaviour, you have to circle back to one's childhood. She writes:

"*Erfarenheten har lärt mig att komplexiteten hos en fullt urvuxen personlighet endast kan förstås om vi får insikt i spädbarnets psyke och kan följa dess utveckling framåt i livet. Det vill säga, analysen banar sig väg från det vuxna livet till spädbarnstiden och genom de mellanliggande stadierna tillbaka till det vuxna livet, i en ständigt upprepande rörelse fram och tillbaka, allt efter den rådande överföringssituationen.* (Klein, Melanie*, Kärlek, skuld och gottgörelse,* Natur & Kultur, page. 306)

I believe that to be true, everything that is experienced will never be gone. I also believe that you carry your parents ages within you. To understand yourself you need to go back in time. Not only looking at your own childhood but also your parents. The scars they carry will always be projected into you, no one sees it or even knows it, but when certain situations occur, we feel it.

Every child has a different childhood. Siblings may share the same parents, the same genes, even the same room in the same house, but the only thing that separates their childhoods is time. Parents are never truly the same people across the years.

If siblings are born several years apart, the circumstances of the parents' lives may have changed: their income, their mindset, the paths they have walked, whether difficult or calm. Everything around them shifts, and with it, the roles within the family.

If you have children close in age, the dynamic is different again. With the first child, everything is new. You are learning how to coexist with a tiny human who depends entirely on you -what it eats, how it sleeps, when it is safe to step outside. The second child is never the first. By then, the parent has learned a little, but the responsibilities have doubled: two sleeping schedules, two appetites, and most of all, two very different wills. Each child brings a unique rhythm to the household, and each experience is distinct, shaped by the ever-changing lives of the parents.

During this changing in time, the dynamics of the family change. When the children get older and have kids on their own, a parent sometimes feel like the youngest person in the room, even with grandchildren present.

My work grows out of this awareness. In my practice, time is fluid. I blend different timelines, allowing my mother's younger self to exist alongside my children, sometimes at the same age, sometimes even younger. A subtle collision of past, present, and imagined futures. Through this, I am trying to trace the invisible threads that connect generations, memory, and material presence. The dynamics never settle, they move and rearrange, like something still trying to find its form.

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Perhaps my longing to be needed comes from my mother's longing. She must have carried a large hole somewhere inside her, a space she tried to fill up with children, and with the men who passed through her life.

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So, what do I really know about why I am who I am and how I come to term with my need to be needed?
Not much.

There are no clear answers to hold on to, only fragments of a larger picture.
The messy room I am trying to make sense of will probably never be cleaned.
And maybe that is a good thing.
A mystery that keeps me searching, keeps me digging, keeps me returning.

Growing up is getting to know the person you were and learn from her but also, come to terms with the mother, who might have given you what she lacked, even if that wasn't what you really needed. The past is always present, whether we like it or not. It can be unsettling, even painful to face but also, oh so intriguing.

I may never fully understand myself as a whole.
And there is where I find my artistic work to be, an endless attempt to make sense of something that resists being resolved.

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